GLIMPSE / ANDROID WALLPAPERS

Glimpse.

Something lovely, every time you look.

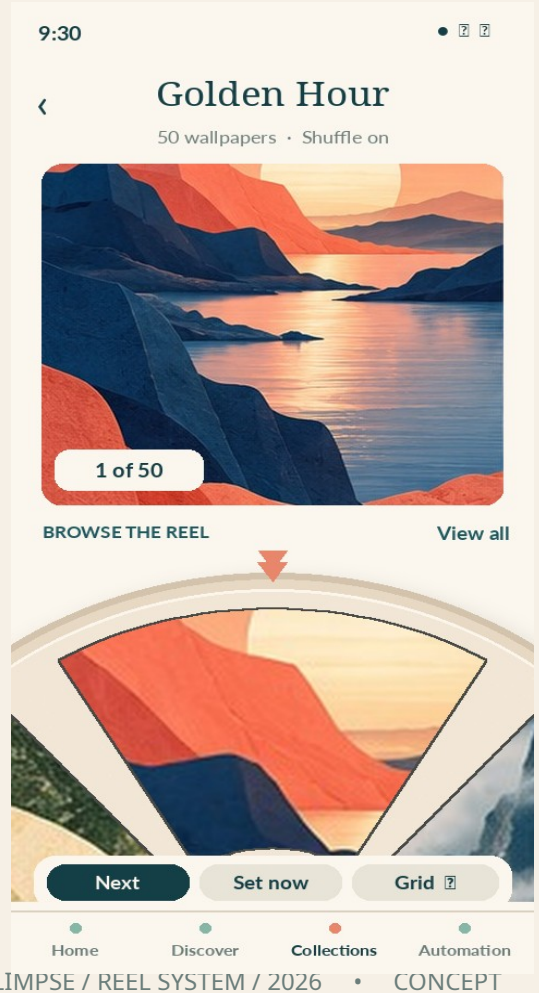
A native Android wallpaper app that makes your screen feel like a window into somewhere else.

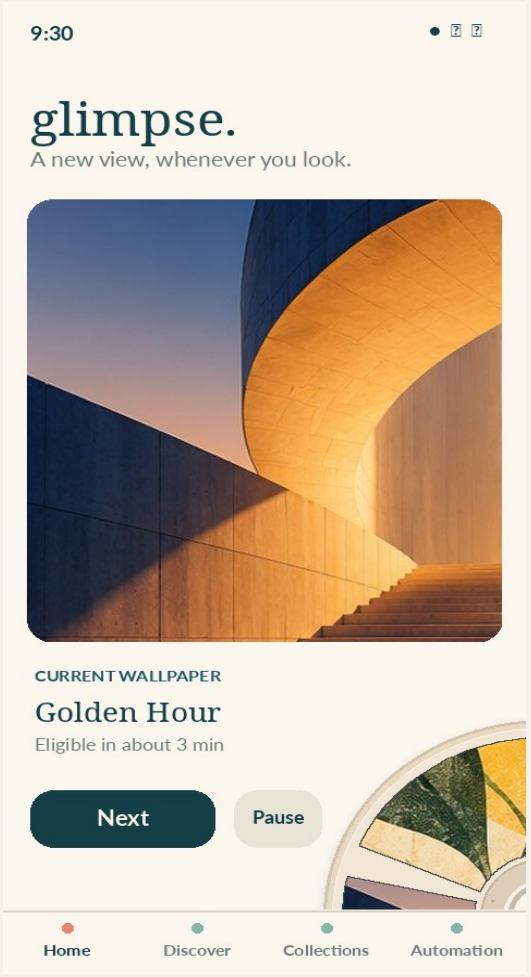


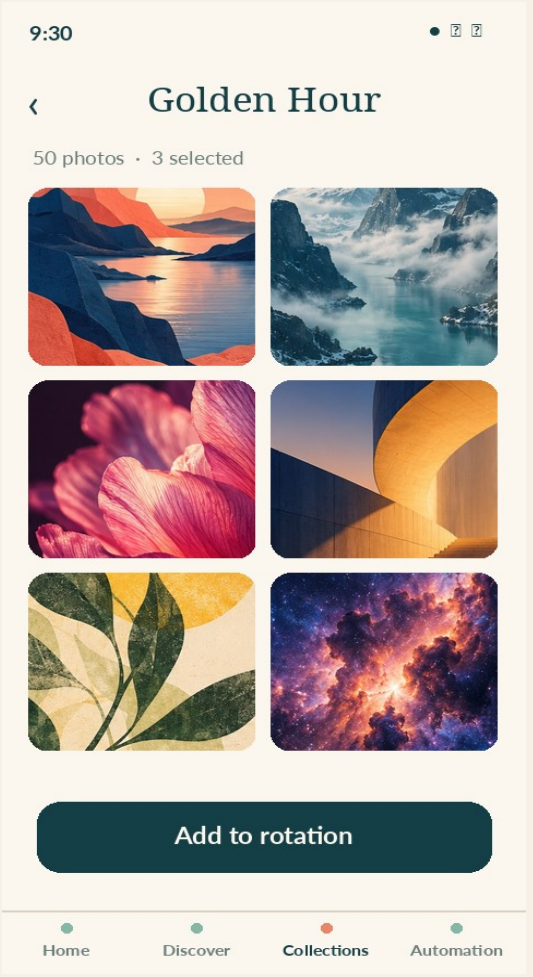
THE PAPER REEL / CONTINUOUS BROWSING / V4

A circle bigger than the screen.

The reel continues beyond the viewport. Only the active arc asks for attention.







01 BROWSE

Oversized reel extends beyond left, right and lower edges.

02 GLANCE

Home shows only a smaller crescent beside the current view.

03 ESCAPE

View all opens the ordinary image grid for serious library work.

A reel, freed from its old machinery.

Five generous photographic windows. Paper, light, movement, surprise.



THE OBJECT

The picture, not the perforation.

A larger opening makes the photograph legible, especially at small sizes. The circular paper shell is now a gentle framework for the imagery, not a historical constraint.

5 windows / 72° per step / pure visual metaphor

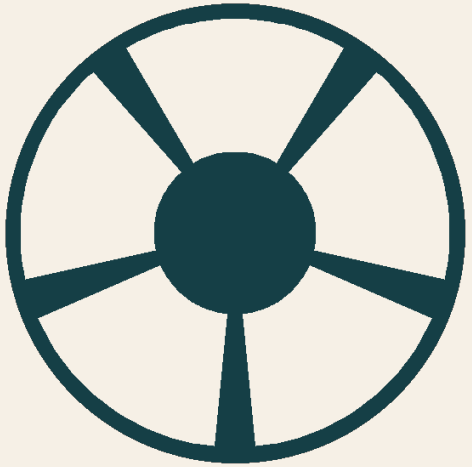
Three expressions of one object.

Different sizes and roles; the same paper, spindle and generous windows.



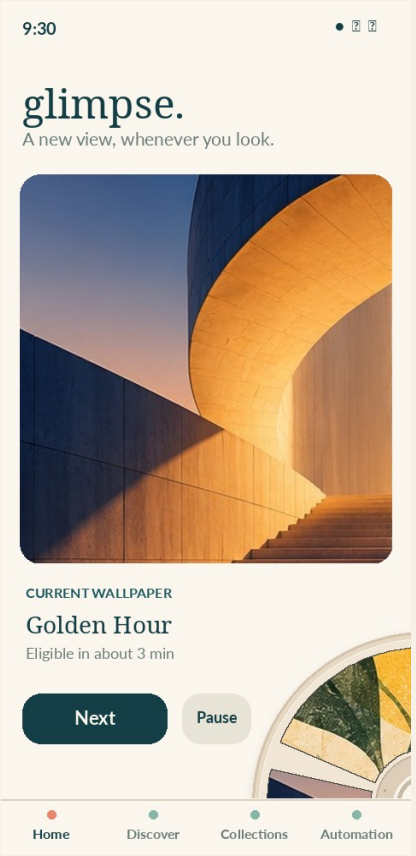
COLOUR REEL

Collection identity



MONOCHROME GLYPH

Android themed icon



IN CONTEXT

The windows move. The collection does not end at five.

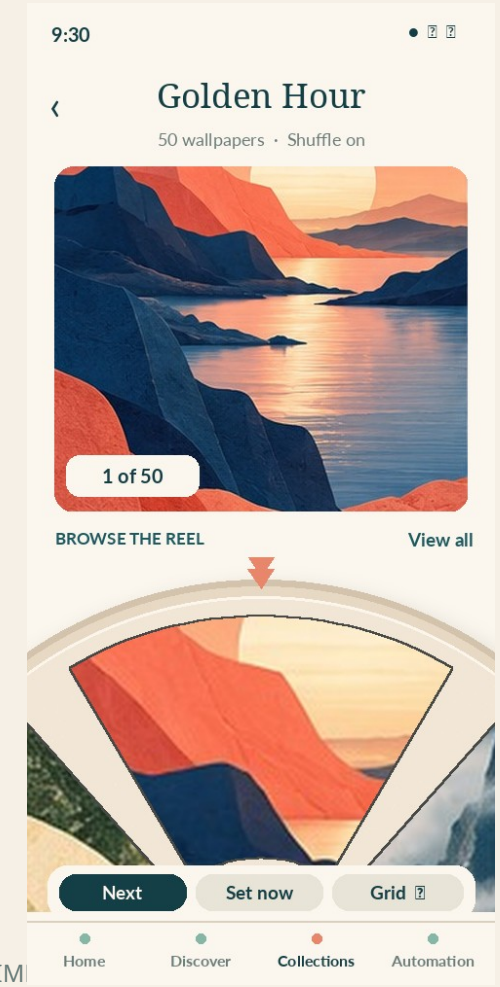
One fixed focal position; a few recycled windows; a stable, durable collection behind them.



A finite collection can wrap for browsing without implying an endless source. At a queue boundary, no-repeat shuffle reseeds explicitly and avoids immediate duplicates.

The preview stays still while the reel advances.

Touch and motion follow the user’s intent. Advancing the browser never silently changes the system wallpaper.



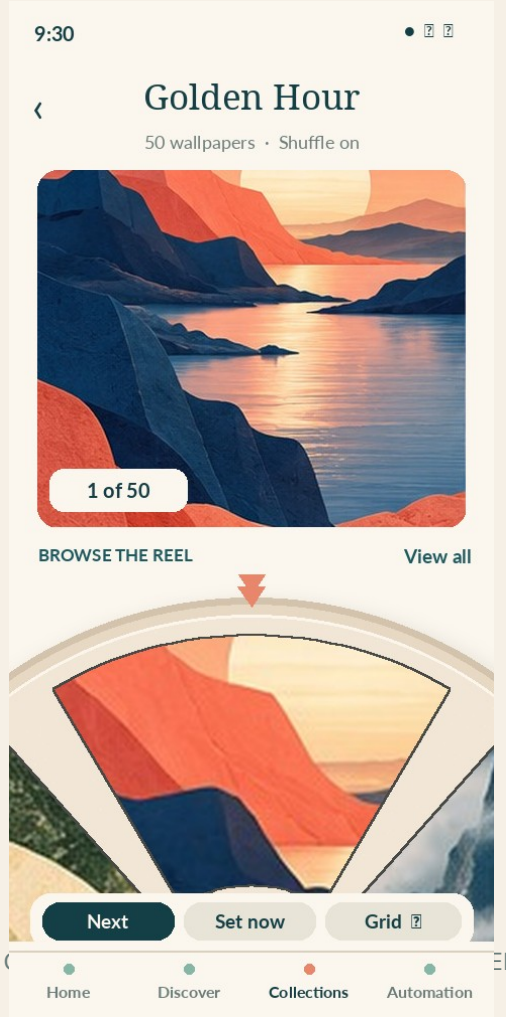


BROWSE **NEXT IMAGE**

Browse = choose what to view. Set now = deliberately apply. The image count follows actual collection membership.

The reel is a beautiful cover, not a storage format.

Each collection can show a distinctive crop of its own artwork.





Rainbows

240 photographs

Open collection



Wild Places

42 photographs

Open collection



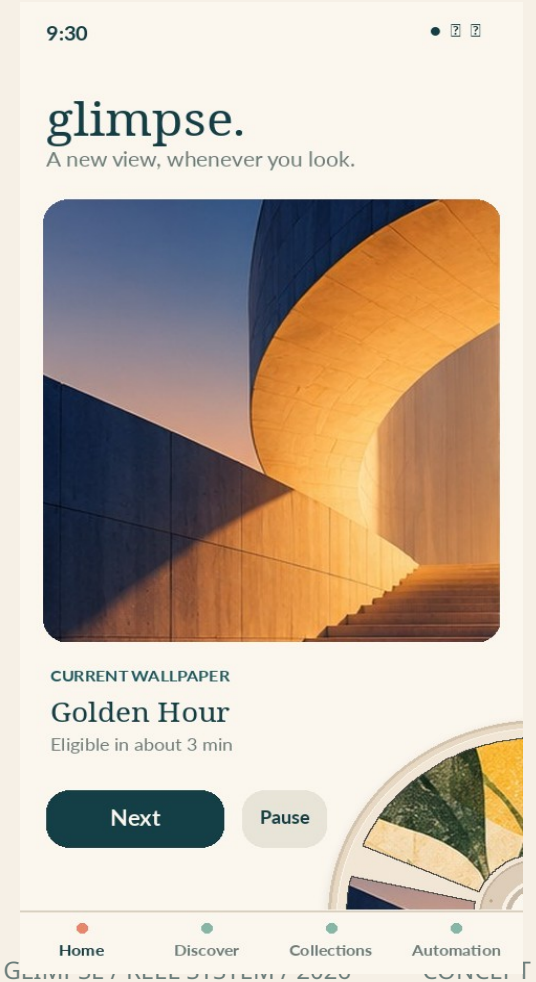
Golden Hour

50 photographs

Open collection

Let the wallpaper take the stage.

A small reel signature on Home, not a full spinning disk on every surface.



Current image first

The photograph takes the most space. Collection context stays nearby.

Immediate actions

Next, Pause, Share and Set now have ordinary labels and 48dp touch targets.

A little reel peeks in

A cropped crescent offers recognition and continuity, not an extra navigation burden.

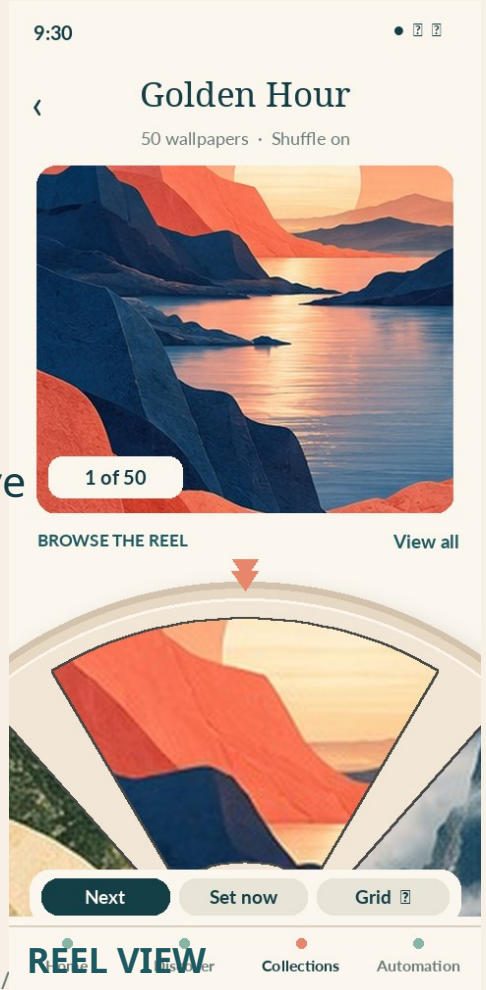
Scheduling stays honest

“Next eligible” refers to Android scheduling; it does not claim a guaranteed exact change.

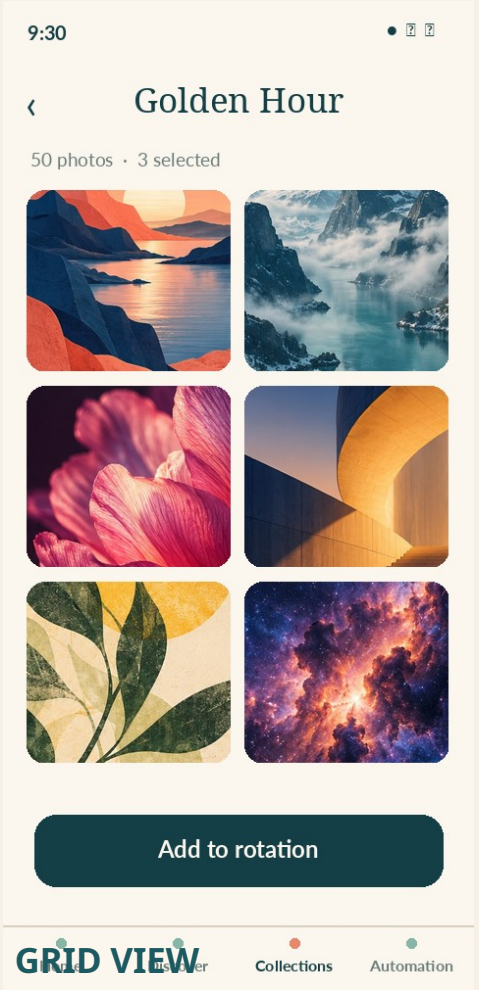
Delight to browse. Efficient to organize.

Two views for the same data. Switch instantly without losing selection or scroll position.

← Immersive inspection



REEL VIEW



GRID VIEW

Fast multi-select →

Poetry around the edges. Clarity in the controls.

Glimpse should feel warm without ever hiding what an action actually does.

WELCOME

Something lovely, every time you look.

BROWSE

Browse the reel · View all

ACTION

Next · Set as wallpaper · Share

STATE

50 wallpapers · Shuffle without repeats

DIAGNOSTICS

Next change eligible in about 3 min

ERROR

Couldn’t change wallpaper. Try now · Details

The illusion must never become an obstacle.

A carousel must remain a usable control when its shape, motion or gesture is unavailable.

Tap targets

Large Next / Previous buttons and a persistent View all option.

TalkBack

A linear list, labelled “Image 12 of 50”; actions in logical reading order.

Reduced motion

Instant image replacement, no reel turn or simulated inertia.

Large text

Text sits outside photographic windows; the reel can shrink or collapse.

Gesture conflict

Vertical scrolling scrolls the page; horizontal drag only in reel region.

No forced wrap

Finite “end of collection” mode or seamless browse loop; users can choose.

Responsive by design, not by shrinking the reel.

Clip to the reel's own container. Keep system bars, tap controls, and content accessibility independent.

SMALL PORTRAIT

Less visible arc

~60–70% of container width visible, with clear Next / Grid buttons.

360dp

LARGE PORTRAIT

Generous arc

More photograph and higher surrounding cards; no tiny windows.

412dp

LANDSCAPE / TABLET

Side-docked reel

Partial disk on the side, hero photograph and actions in the remaining pane.

> 600dp

A continuous reel is a viewport, not an infinite bitmap.

Reuse a handful of window nodes, keep position as a stable asset ID, and avoid unbounded list indexes.

Domain	collection IDs + deterministic order + shuffle queue + current index
Projection	current + 2 neighbours each side; recycled five-window snapshot
Gesture	pointer input → velocity threshold → one notch snap → selected ID
Rendering	Compose Canvas paths + clipped Coil image thumbnails at bounded resolution
Persistence	save image ID and browsing order; return after process death at same item
Testing	fuzz reorder/remove, empty/singleton sets, state restore, RTL, talkback

A little theatre. No deception.

The illusion represents movement through a collection, never a claim of endless new photographs.

End of collection

For Browse All, allow finite stop or opt-in wrap. For Shuffle, mark new cycle and avoid recent repeats.

Large collections

Never load every bitmap. Load neighbouring previews and keep random access through Grid and Search.

Active wallpaper

Browsing changes only the preview. “Set now” explicitly asks Android to apply the chosen asset.

Touch and motion

Reel steps are deliberate and short; no continuous spinning, auto-advance or audio by default.

Keep the tactile paper. Give the photographs room.

This is Glimpse’s signature interaction; everything else stays legible, native and easy.



THE DESIGN BET

A small window into somewhere else.

Icon: five large photographic windows.
Collection: reel as thumbnail cover.
Browser: oversized partial reel.
Home: restrained reel accent.
Grid: always one tap away.

The earlier research is retained.

The following slides capture the existing Glimpse product analysis, initial exploratory UI and the Android engineering plan. Some embedded mockup screenshots reflect the pre-reel design and are superseded by the new reel concepts.

Previous visual explorations

Useful interaction patterns remain; old image assets are evidence of the design process, not the chosen look.

Native architecture unchanged

Kotlin, Compose, Room, reliable wallpaper delivery, secure imports, universal sharing and signed APKs remain the implementation direction.

The phone can feel alive.

A beautiful experience with the dependability of a well-designed system.

01

Yours first

Local folders, carefully vetted providers, no Glimpse account.

02

It keeps its promises

A persistent rule engine and an honest account of every change.

03

Android native

Widgets, Quick Settings, shortcuts, shares and separate destinations.

04

Delight, deliberately

A warm visual language, polished motion and full accessibility.

The category's problem is trust.

The best inspiration came from real bug reports, not feature marketing.

01

Silent schedule failure

Changes stop after sleep, reboot or battery management, with little explanation.

02

Broken image references

Deleted files, rescans and invalid grants can lead to black wallpapers.

03

Source instability

Third-party API changes and rights restrictions interrupt online collections.

04

Surprising controls

What "random", "every 15 minutes" and "on unlock" mean varies by app.

SOPHISTICATED, NOT STERILE

A little personality. A lot of restraint.

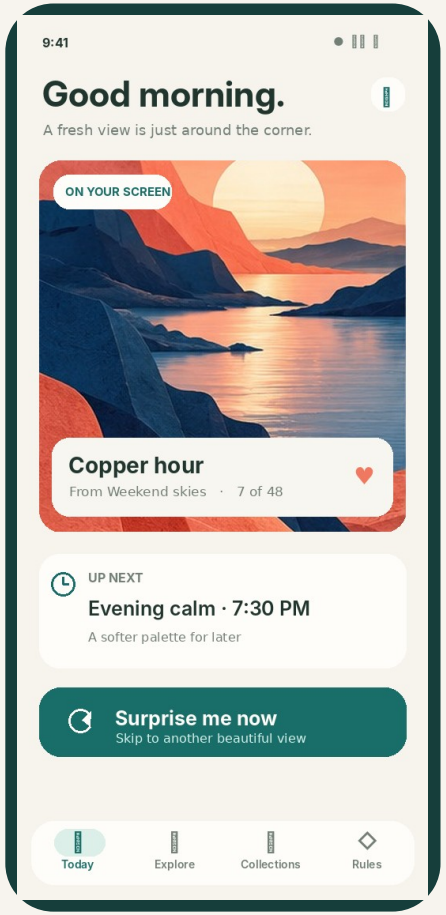
Warm paper, generous breathing room, playful geometry and imagery that does the talking.

SOUND DESIGN, NO DECORATIVE NOISE

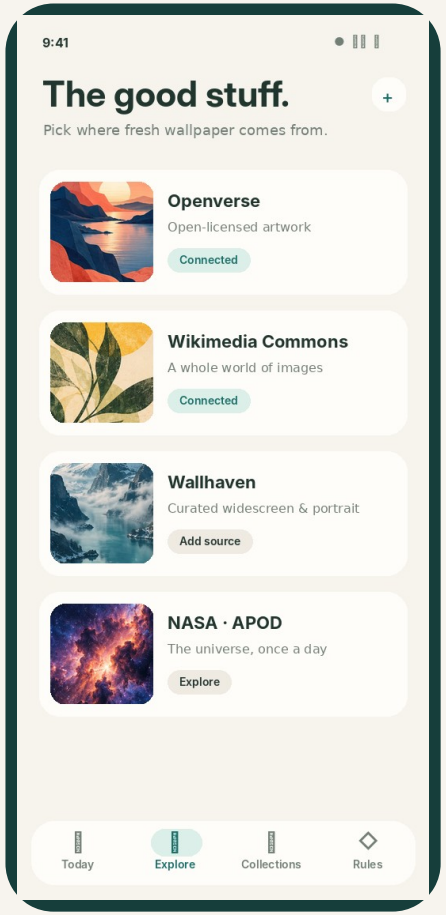


Four places, one clear mental model.

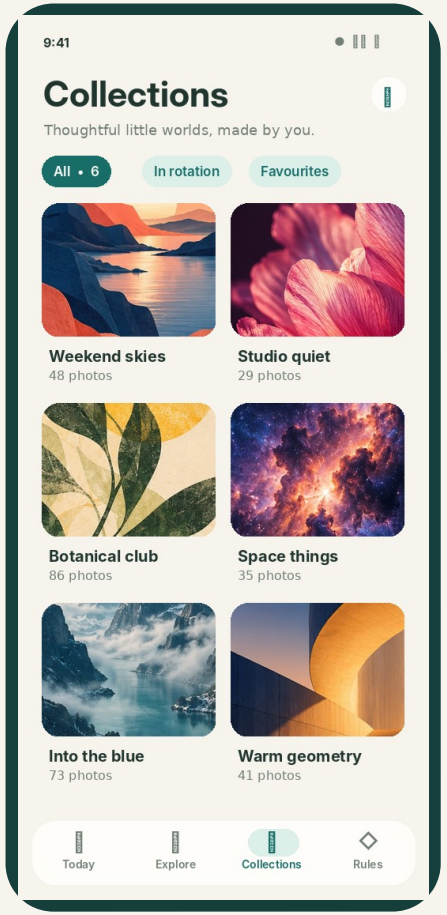
Today · Explore · Collections · Rules. Activity and Settings are one tap away.



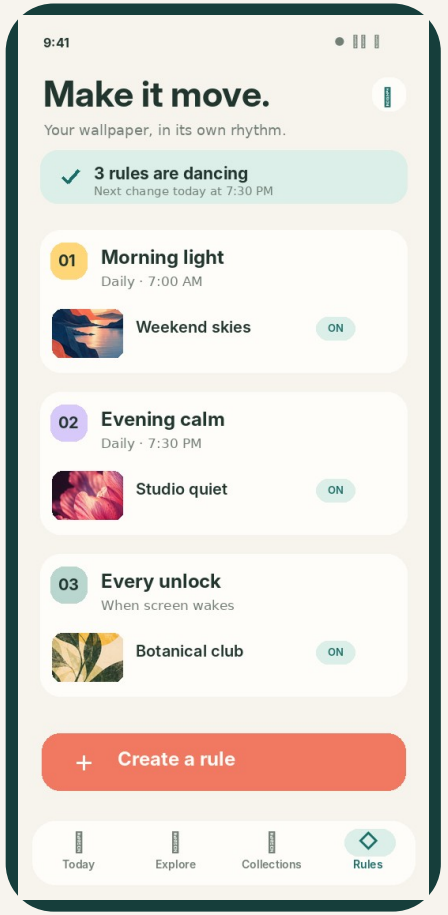
TODAY



EXPLORE



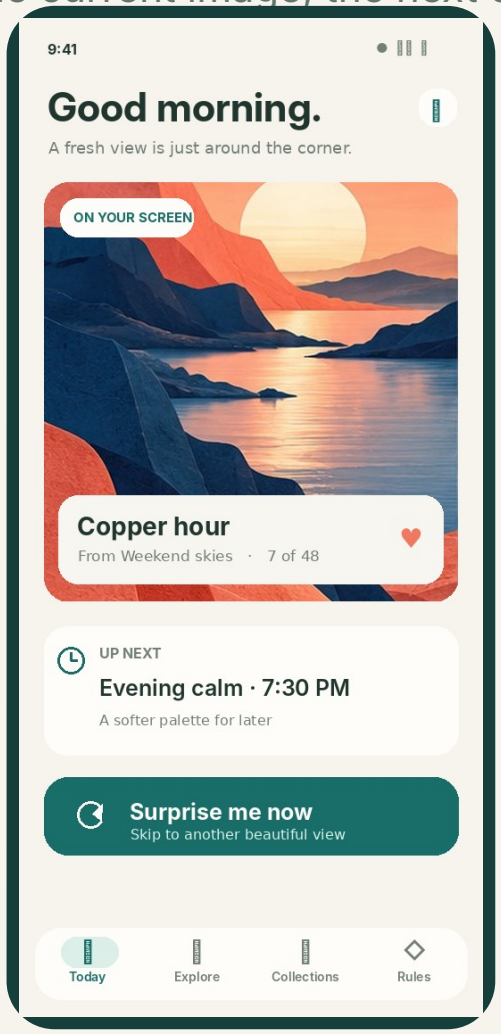
COLLECTIONS



RULES

Today feels effortless.

The current image, the next event and one large action.



One dominant action

Surprise me now is immediate. No screen full of obscure settings.

Status in plain language

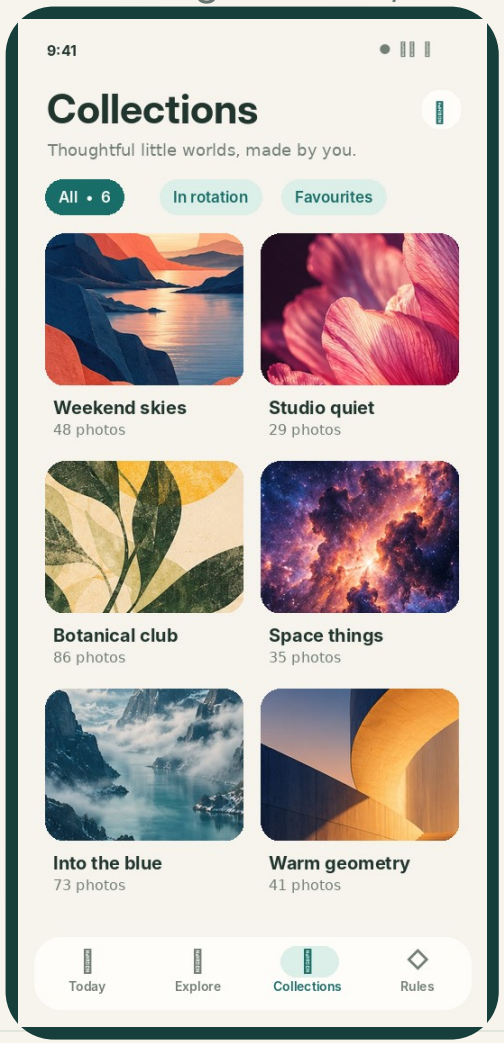
Show the source, the rotation position and the next eligible action.

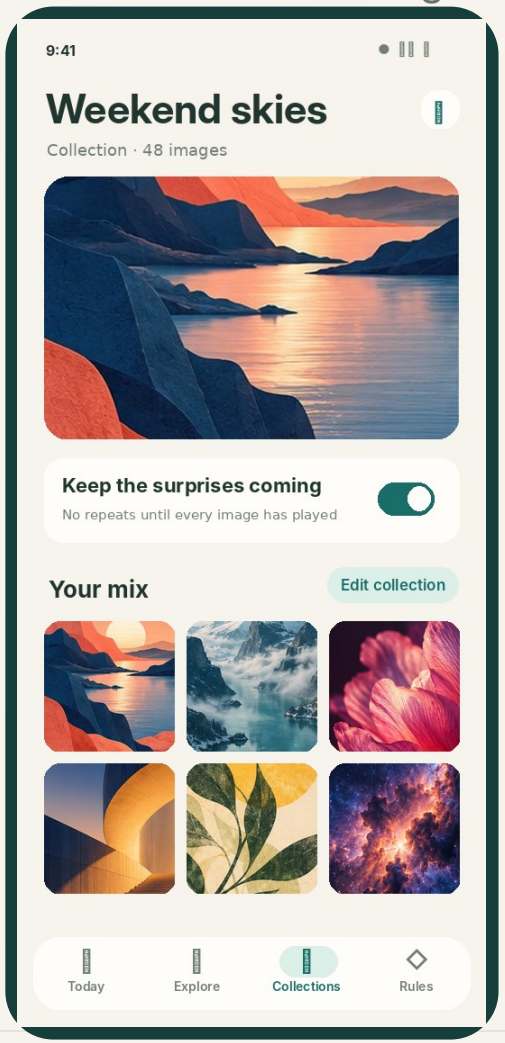
Never leave the user guessing

Pause, inspect, undo or diagnose are discoverable without being noisy.

A library without a proprietary library.

Powerful organization, entirely built on the user's existing files and links.





Thoughtful collections

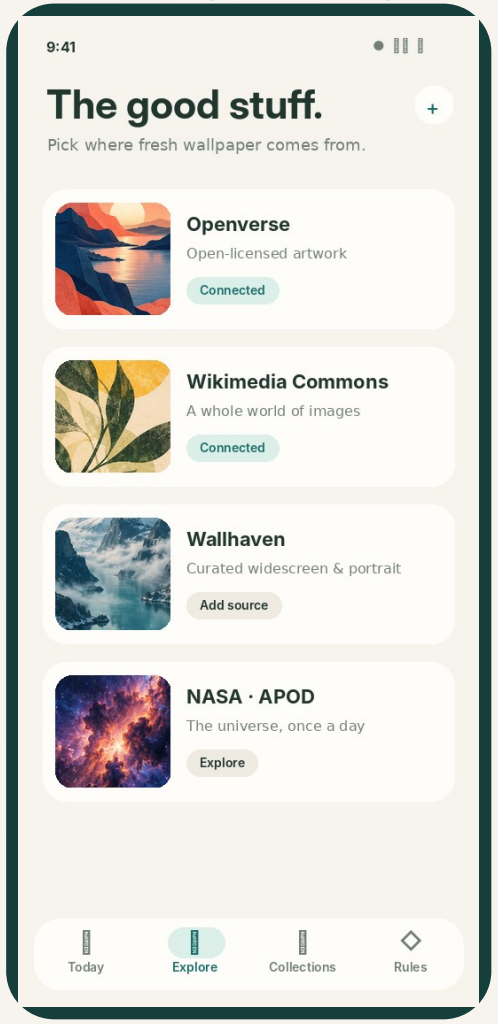
Manual sets, watched folders, smart filters, favourites, exclusions and a persistent no-repeat shuffle bag.

NO DUPLICATED USER LIBRARY

Images stay where they belong. Only small, bounded and disposable render caches live inside Glimpse.

The world's images, through legitimate doors.

Provider adapters keep discovery, rights and automation separate.



YOUR FILES	Offline by default
WIKIMEDIA COMMONS	Open-licensed metadata
OPENVERSE	Search across open works
WALLHAVEN	Public API + optional own key
NASA APOD	Rights-screened images

Content provenance is a product feature.

Every wallpaper carries its source, creator, licence and origin link.

01

Integrated with permission

Wikimedia Commons, Openverse and Wallhaven, subject to terms and per-image rights.

02

NASA with nuance

Some APOD images are third-party copyrighted. Gate automatic use accordingly.

03

Not default: Unsplash

Its published API policy restricts replica wallpaper applications.

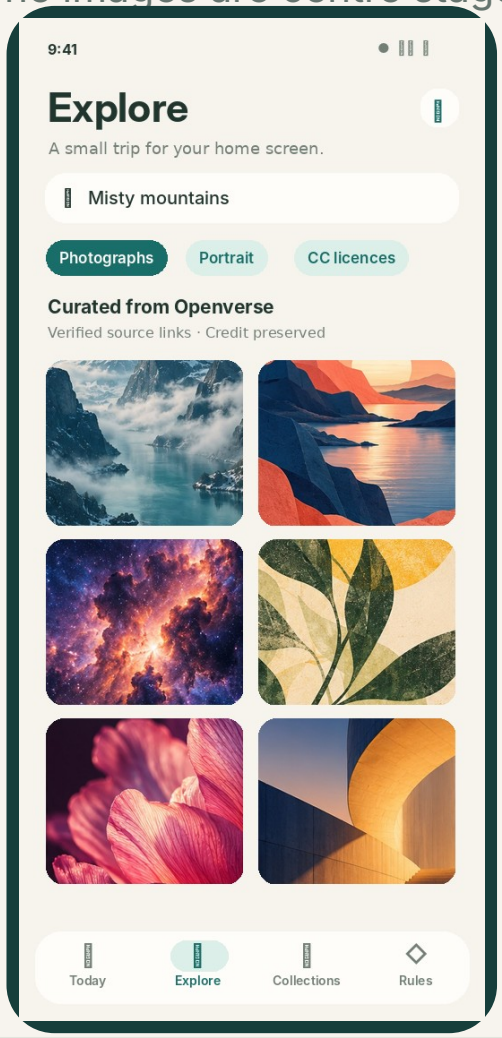
04

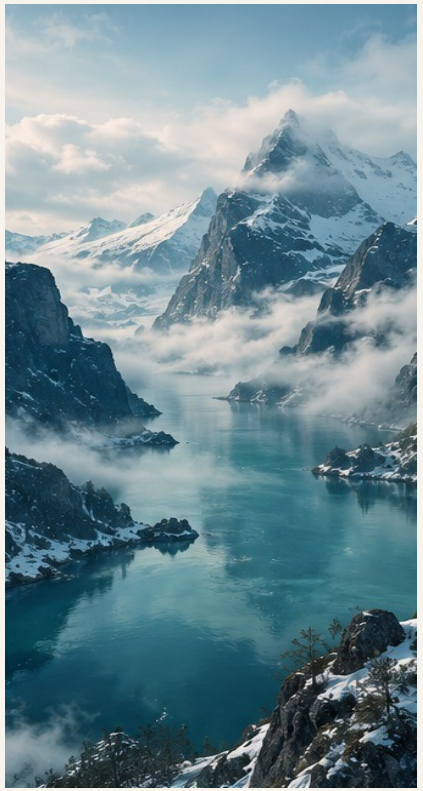
Not default: Pexels

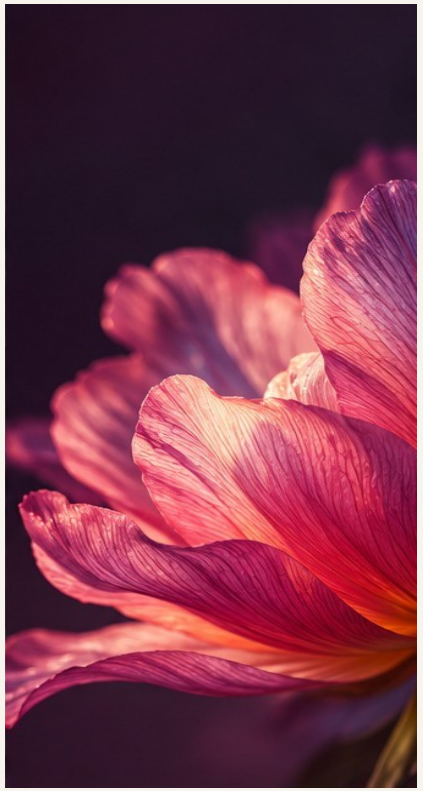
Its API likewise explicitly restricts wallpaper applications.

Browse with curiosity. Save with confidence.

The images are centre stage; credit and licences stay attached.





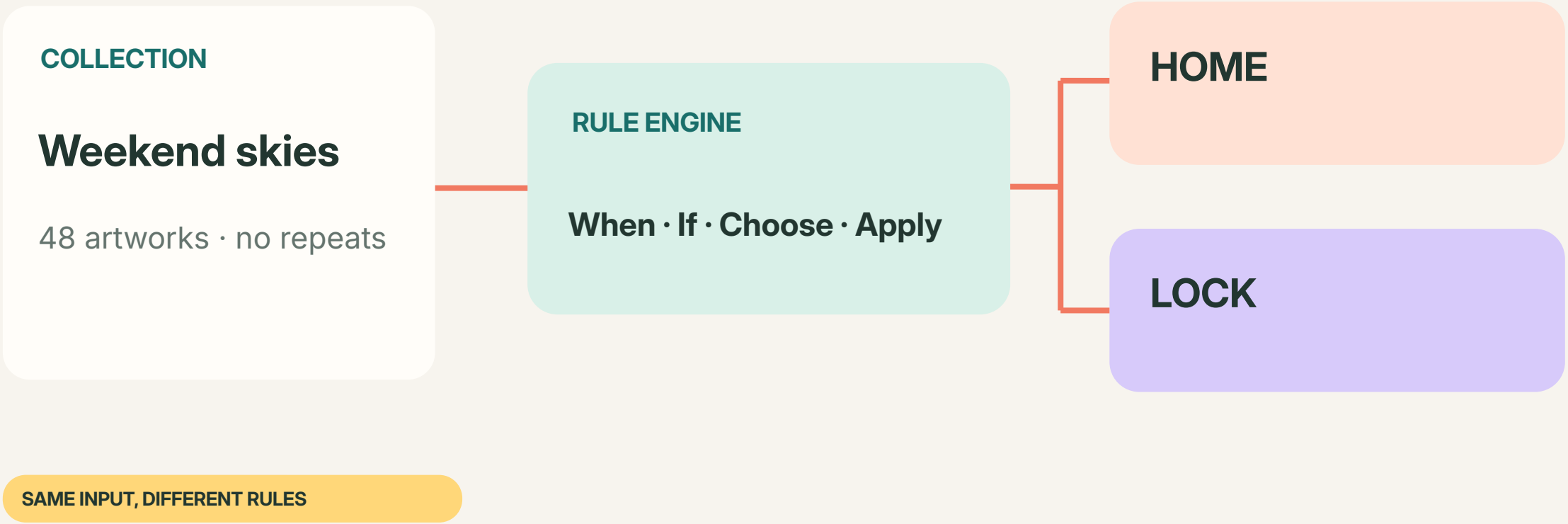




Portrait-aware search • image-rights filters • source links

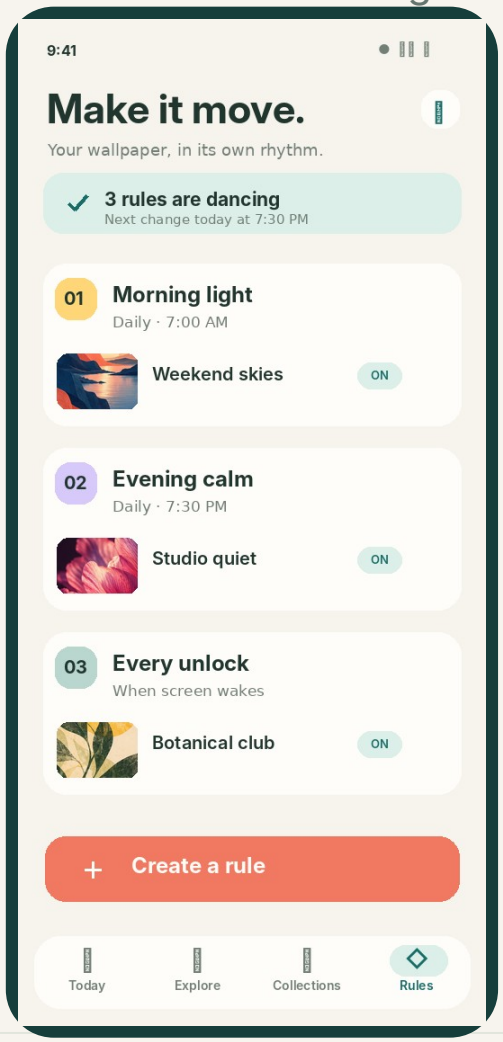
Collections and rules stay independent.

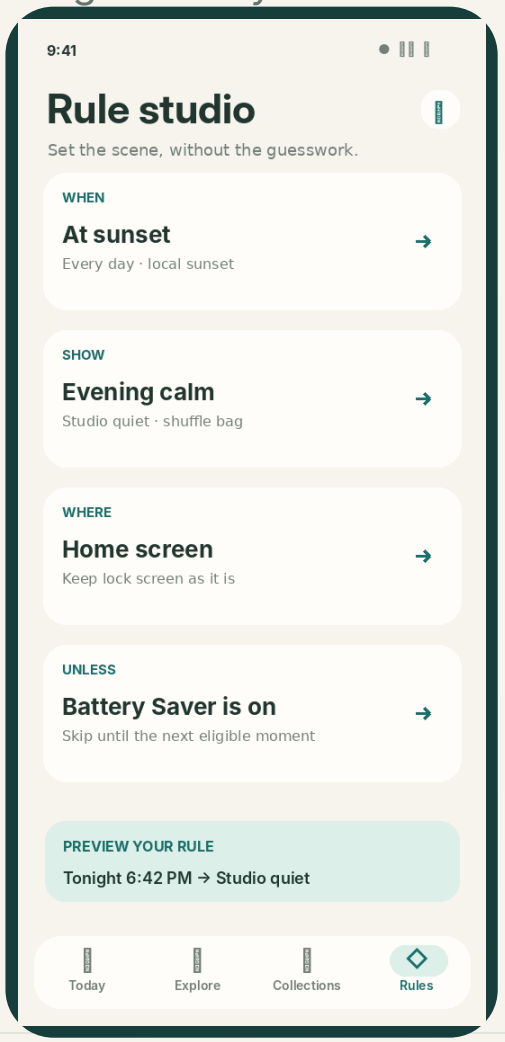
A scene can reuse a collection across destinations and contexts.



Automation reads like a sentence.

Power when desired. A gentle learning curve by default.





WHEN At sunset

SHOW Evening calm

WHERE Home only

UNLESS Battery Saver

SIMULATE BEFORE SAVING

Predictable priorities, every time.

An inspectable evaluation pipeline makes advanced automation safe.

01 Trigger

Time, unlock, widget, intent

02 Eligibility

Pause, permissions, conditions

03 Resolution

Priority + stable tie-break

04 Selection

Persistent shuffle reservation

05 Delivery

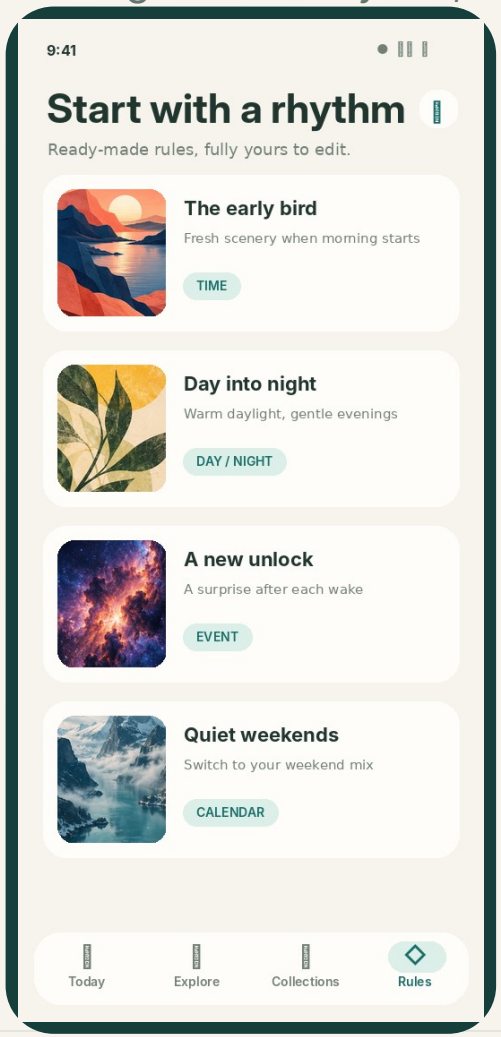
Prepare → apply → reconcile

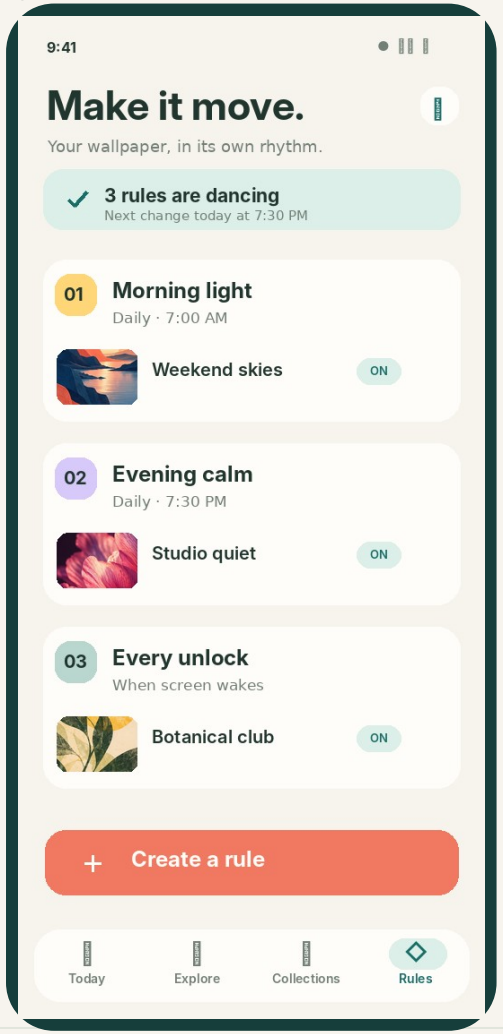
06 Explanation

Success, skip or failure record

Good defaults. Endless combinations.

Users begin with a rhythm, then adjust one idea at a time.





Time of day

Morning scenes and evening calm, with DST-aware window logic.

Context

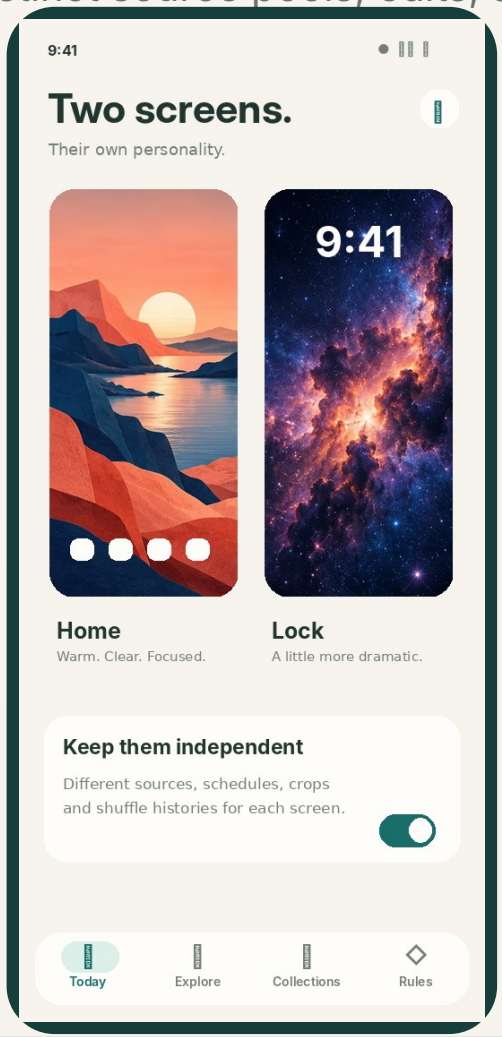
Weekends, power settings and source availability.

Events

Quick Settings, widgets and optional capability-gated wake mode.

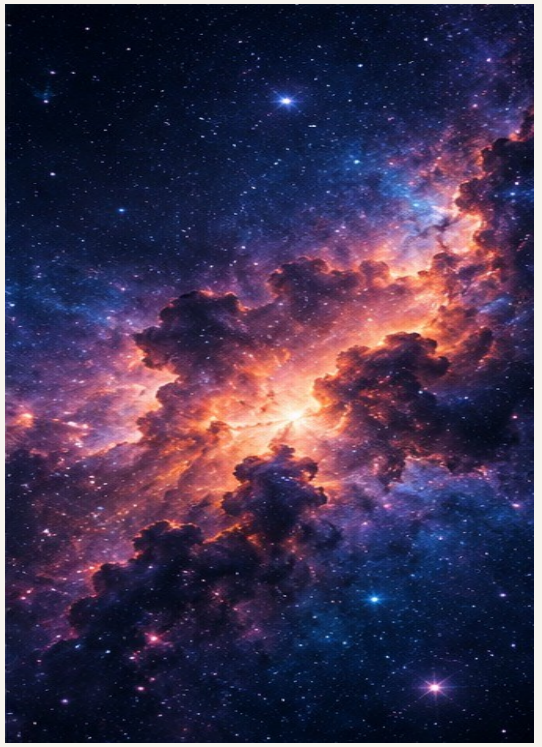
Home and lock deserve their own rhythm.

Distinct source pools, edits, shuffle histories and transition policies.





HOME

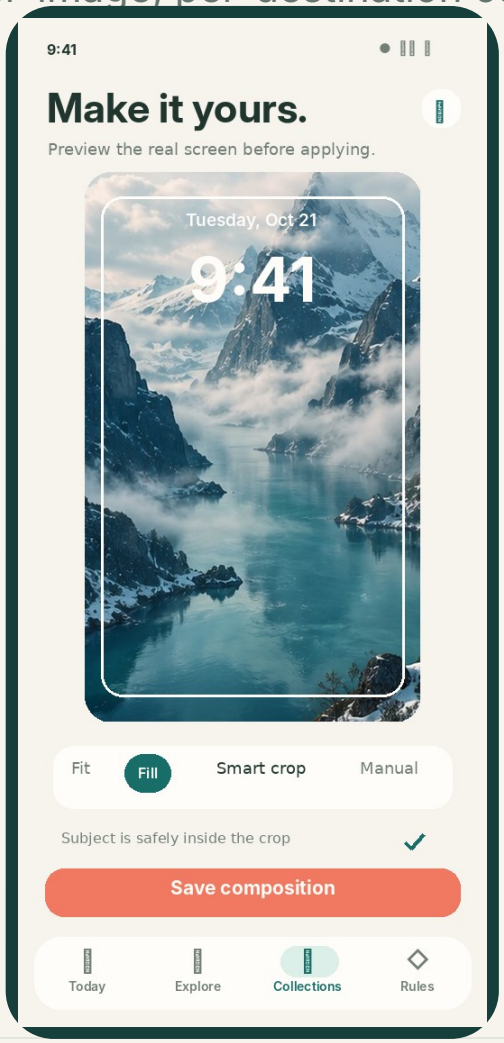


LOCK

Destination capabilities are detected, not assumed.

Never lose the subject to a bad crop.

Per-image, per-destination composition. Completely reversible.



See the actual frame

Lock clock, launch grid and portrait aspect guides in preview.

Three levels of agency

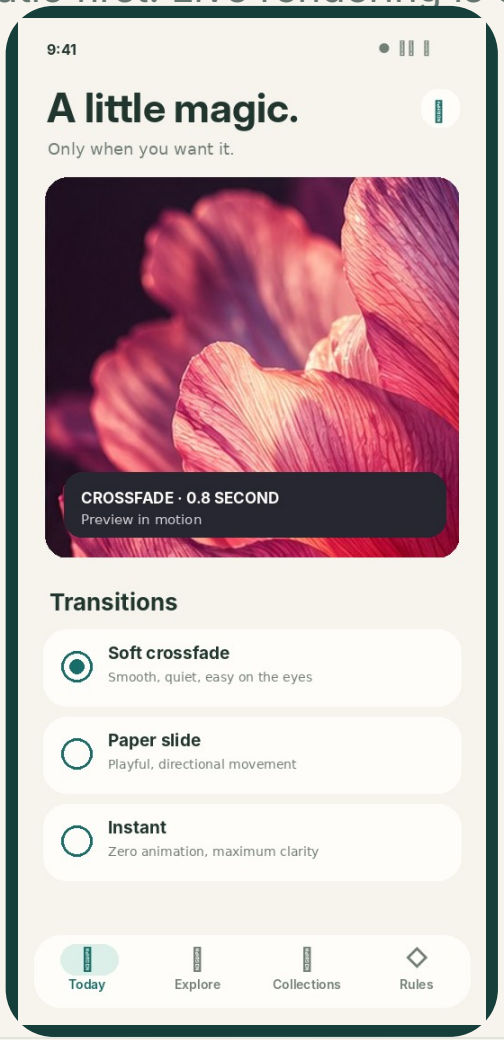
Auto-fill, smart focal suggestion, or precise pinch-and-pan controls.

Respect originals

Only transform render copies, and preserve editing history.

Motion is a treat, never a tax.

Static first. Live rendering is optional and must behave when invisible.



01

Instant

One prepared image and a direct Android static wallpaper update.

02

Soft crossfade

A restrained live transition that respects reduced motion.

03

Paper slide

A playful optional treatment with predictable GPU cost.

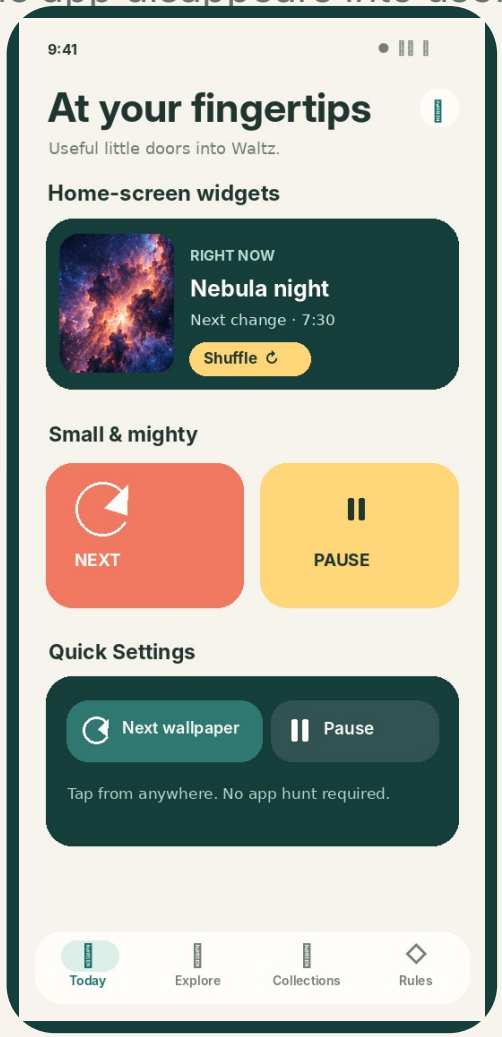
04

Silence by default

Animations stop when the live surface is not visible.

Present wherever Android expects it.

The app disappears into useful native controls.



01

Glance widgets

Now / Next, one-tap Shuffle, Pause and full-screen preview.

02

Quick Settings

Discoverable tile request for Skip and Pause / Resume.

03

Pinned shortcuts

Jump to a collection or trigger Next from launcher.

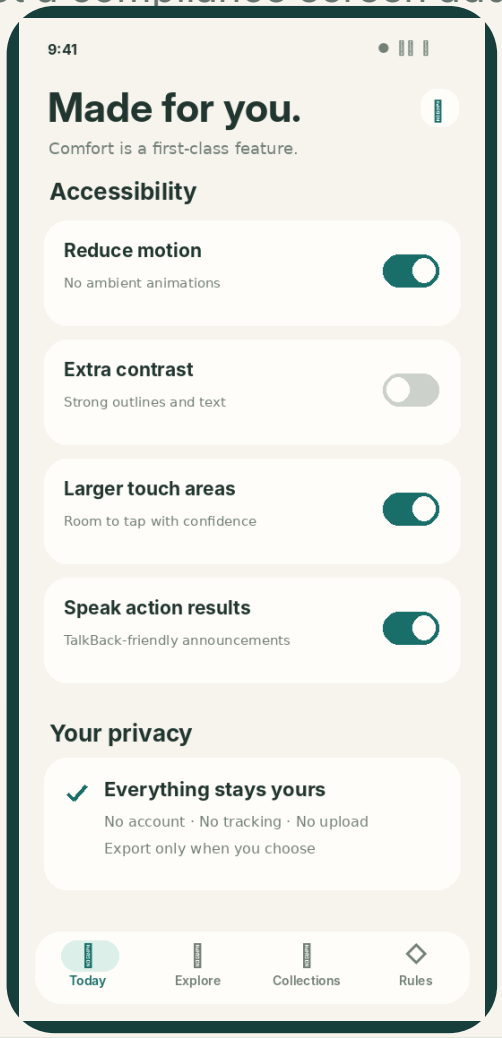
04

Automation contracts

Documented intent entry point for tools such as Tasker.

Accessibility changes the design for the better.

Not a compliance screen added the week before release.



48 dp

minimum touch targets

200%

scalable text acceptance

AA

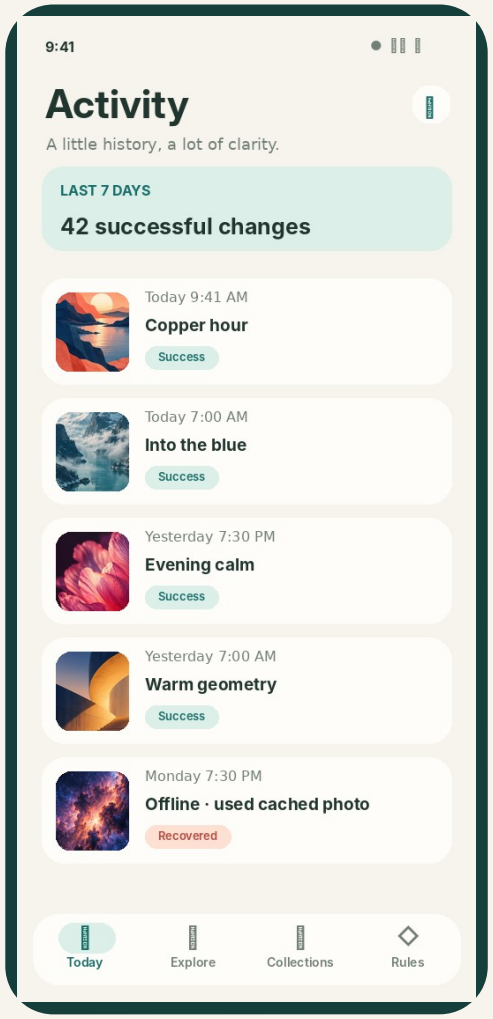
target contrast standard

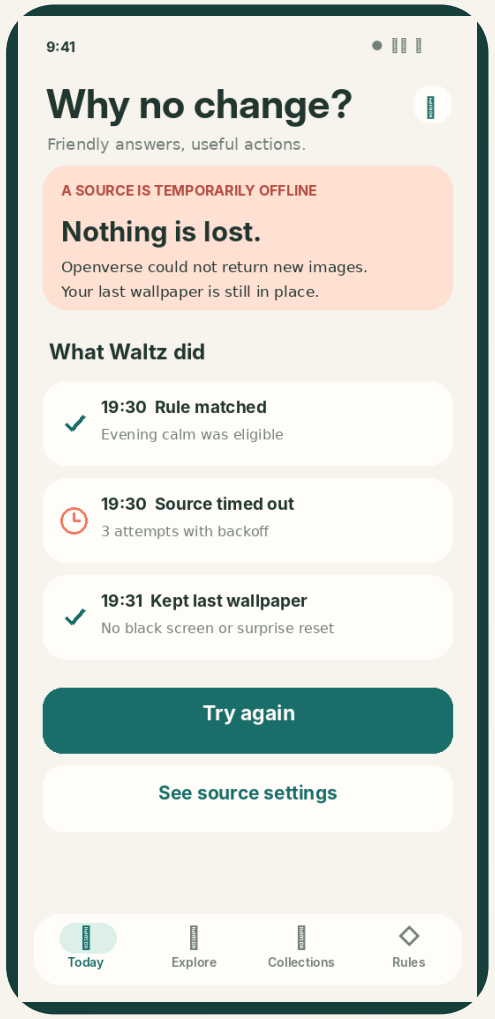
Zero

motion-dependent tasks

When things fail, the app explains itself.

A diary of real outcomes, not a decorative “working” spinner.





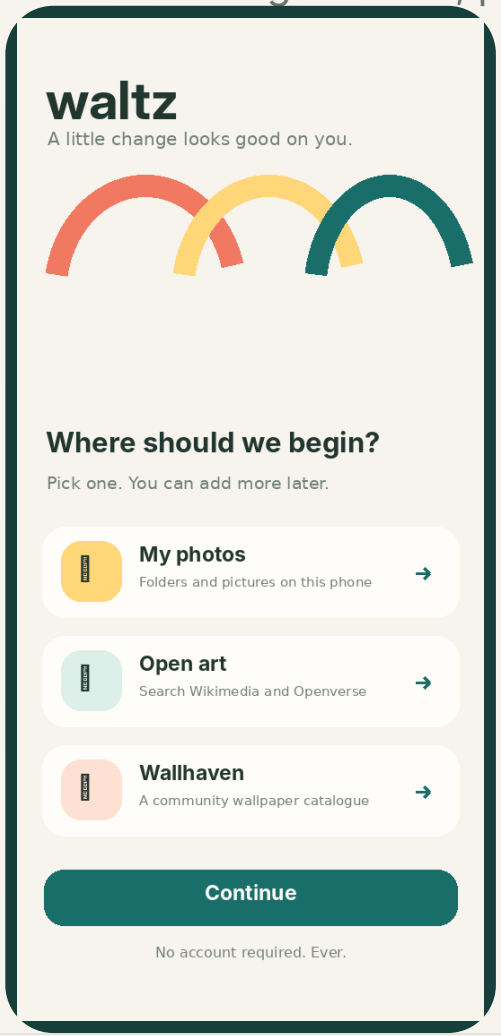
Actionable answers

Why it did not change
Which rule was eligible
What source failed
What was preserved
When it will retry

NEVER REPLACE WITH BLACK

Onboarding that does not interrogate.

Start with an image source, preview, then choose a rhythm.



01 **Pick existing photos or a vetted source**

02 **Preview at your real screen ratio**

03 **Choose home, lock or both**

04 **Select a ready-made rhythm**

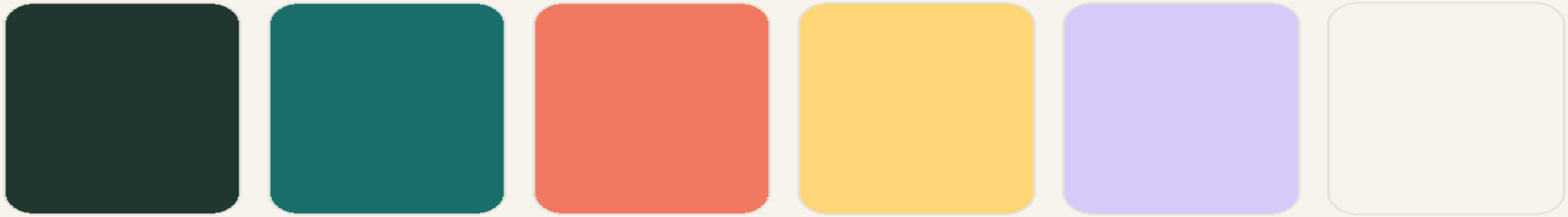
No account. No gallery upload. No universal permission request.

A design system with a pulse.

Delight in colour relationships, not loudness.

A visual language that smiles.

Soft surfaces. Confident contrast. A little sparkle in the corners.



Ink	Tidal teal	Apricot	Butter	Lilac	Paper
#223630	#196E6A	#F17961	#FFD779	#D7CAFA	#F7F4EE

WALTZ / UI SYSTEM 01

The icon, tokens and components belong together.

Friendly geometry with clear interaction affordances.



PRIMARY ACTION

SECONDARY ACTION

ATTENTION

SCHEDULED

Wide hit areas, low visual noise, and unmistakable state.

A modular engine underneath the warmth.

A source is a provider. A rule is a decision. A delivery is a device action.

SOURCE ADAPTERS — Local · Commons · Openverse · Wallhaven

LOCAL REPOSITORY — Room · metadata · licences · bounded cache

PURE RULE ENGINE — Triggers · conditions · conflicts · shuffle

RENDER PIPELINE — Decode · crop · prepare · effects

ANDROID OUTPUT — WallpaperManager · live Engine · widgets

We tell the truth about Android.

The operating system gets the final vote on background execution.

01

Inexact schedules

Periodic WorkManager has a 15-minute minimum and can be deferred.

02

Event limitations

Wake and lock triggers need explicitly supported lifecycle modes.

03

OEM behavior

Battery managers, launchers and lock surfaces vary substantially.

04

Capability gating

Show only features the actual device can reliably support.

Privacy by architecture, not by policy copy.

The app needs no cloud of its own because nothing essential leaves the device.

01	**NO ACCOUNT**	No identifiers, logins or proprietary hosted galleries.
02	**PERMISSION MINIMALISM**	User-selected folder/document access instead of all-files.
03	**CREDENTIAL CARE**	Sensitive keys in secure device storage, never in URLs/logs.
04	**DIAGNOSTICS ON DEVICE**	Explicit review and export; no secret analytics SDK.

Build reliability first. Delight on a stable foundation.

Milestones are vertical slices with exit criteria, not a gallery of unfinished UI.

01

Platform proof

2–3 wk

02

Local core

4–5 wk

03

Rules + diagnostics

3–4 wk

04

External sources

3–4 wk

05

Native surfaces

2–3 wk

06

Live + hardening

5–9 wk

The test matrix is part of the product.

A great experience must survive boredom, abuse and real-world Android.

01

Import torture

20k images, cancelled indexing, restored URI grants, database migrations.

02

Long sleep & reboot

Doze, offline recovery, missed intervals, DST and process death.

03

Rendering gauntlet

Orientation churn, GPU limits, launcher replacement and live visibility.

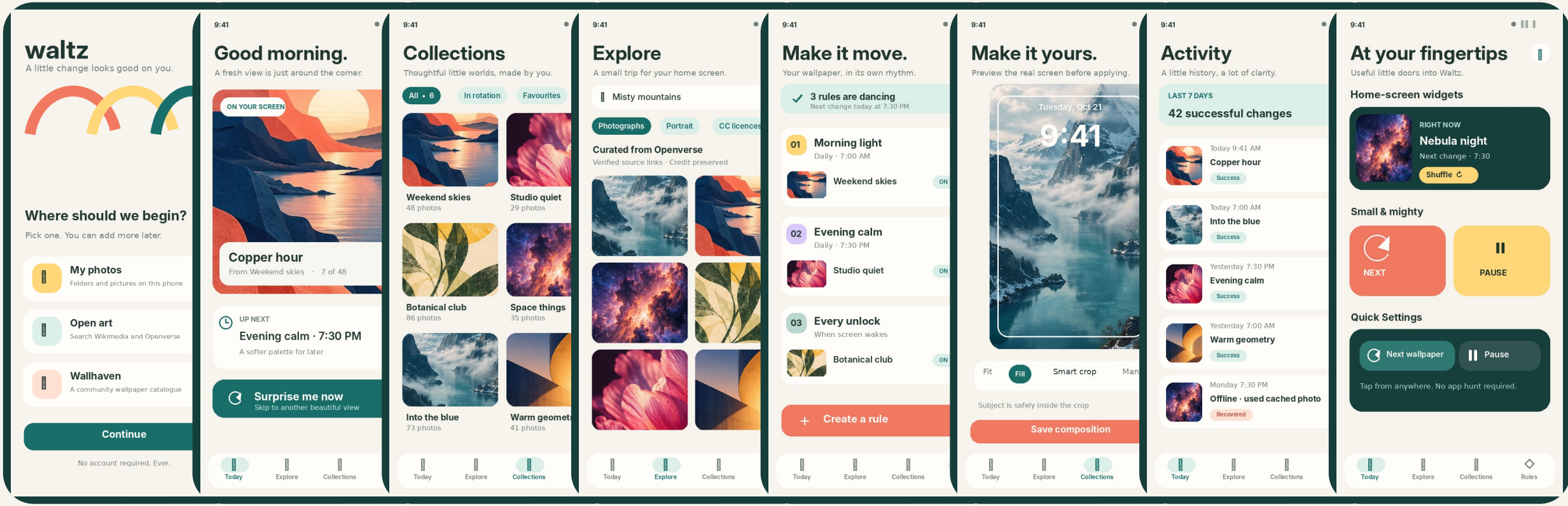
04

Inclusive completion

TalkBack, keyboard, 200% text, contrast and reduced motion.

Sixteen screens, one unmistakable personality.

From first run to diagnosis, every state belongs to the same system.



Full sixteen-screen gallery and downloadable PNG files accompany this deck.

A wallpaper manager worth keeping.

Yours to curate.
Yours to automate.
Yours to understand.

GLIMPSE / PRODUCT CONCEPT / 2026



Rainbows in five minutes

One familiar native photo picker. One collection. One rhythm. No rule editor.

1 New collection
Rainbows

2 Add photos
Android Photo Picker

3 Import offline
Count successes & duplicates

4 Use as wallpaper
Home screen

5 Shuffle
Every five minutes

6 Start
Next / Pause / Why

A kind promise, never a fake one

Google Photos selection is a snapshot. Five-minute rotation is active-use eligibility, with honest OS delays.

Import your picks

Album browsing depends on Android Photo Picker provider. Whole-album select and continuous sync are not guaranteed.

Keep them offline

Verified app-private copies, resumable errors, original photos untouched.

Show what happened

Last applied, next eligible, reason for deferral, and a one-tap remedy.

W A L T Z / COMPLEXITY WITHOUT CONFUSION

73 lives. Four levels of control.

The engine is composable. The interface only reveals complexity when it earns its keep.

1 / Act

Next · Pause · Hide · Pin

2 / Pick a rhythm

Shuffle · interval · destinations

3 / Make a scene

Workday · Travel · Rainbows

4 / Add rules

When · If · Use · Where · Unless

Make the small thing impeccable

Ship the Rainbow test before the exotic recursive composition engine.

MVP: photos → private offline copies → collection → no-repeat shuffle → five-minute active-use rotation.

Next: scenes, rule precedence, widgets, sources, backup, diagnostics.

Then: nested collection DAGs, weighted mixes, intelligent crops and optional live rendering.

An actual Android app. No detours.

A signed, sideloadable APK with Kotlin and first-party Android platform integrations.

UI & interaction

Jetpack Compose + Material 3
Navigation 3
ViewModel + StateFlow
Accessible Glimpse design tokens

Durable foundations

Room / SQLite transactions
DataStore preferences
Coroutines & Flow
Hilt dependency injection

Native distribution

API 29 minimum (proposed)
API 37 target (qualification)
Gradle version catalogue
Signed and checksum-verified APK

One command path, everywhere.

Widgets, timers, the UI, and Android share intents all use the same domain commands.

ENTRY POINTS	App • widgets • tiles • shortcuts • triggers
COMMAND GATEWAY	Validate • authorize • deduplicate • serialize
PURE RULE ENGINE	Scenes • conditions • weighted shuffle • explanation
PERSISTENT OPERATION	Room state • journal • outbox • recoverable results
ANDROID DELIVERY	WallpaperManager • optional live engine • capabilities

An operation journal, not a hopeful timer.

The Android wallpaper API cannot join a database transaction; Glimpse records intent and reconciles outcomes.

01 REQUEST	Record the source trigger, image, destination and idempotency key.
02 PREPARE	Resolve a valid asset; decode within memory limits and render the crop.
03 APPLY	Call WallpaperManager, capture the actual platform result.
04 RECONCILE	Persist success or failure; retry safely after an interruption.
05 EXPLAIN	Show what changed, what failed, and the next eligible change.

Five minutes means something precise.

Sideloading does not defeat Doze, battery restrictions or Android foreground-service rules.

Static / efficient

- OS-managed scheduling
- Sub-15-minute intervals are best effort
- Resume at next permitted opportunity

Live / optional

- WallpaperService.Engine
- Animate while wallpaper is visible
- Stop work when invisible

Truthful interface

- Last applied
- Next eligible
- Why delayed?
- Manual Next remains accessible

The originals are sacred.

Images, collection membership, edit recipes and generated caches are separate objects.

Into Glimpse

Google Photos picker
Screenshot share or Paste
Storage Access Framework
Approved remote providers

In Glimpse

Verify and copy offline
Hash and detect duplicates
Edit non-destructively
Bound image decoding

Out of Glimpse

Android wallpaper targets
Share to compatible apps
Export original or crop
Optional metadata removal

Belong on the phone, not just in the app.

System integration is built on supported contracts and explicit permissions.

At a glance

Glance widgets: Next, Pause, Now playing. Compact bitmap memory use.

From anywhere

Quick Settings tile, launcher shortcuts and compatible automation intents.

Share in and out

Photo Picker, Android Sharesheet, FileProvider grants and external editor return flows.

Keep access scoped

No blanket file access, invisible clipboard monitoring or fake direct Lens APIs.

An APK people can trust to install.

Sideloading makes signing identity, upgrade safety and provenance first-class requirements.

Build with discipline

Pinned Gradle toolchain
Dependency verification
Secret scanning
PR checks and migrations

Test in the real world

Pixel 6 Pro + Samsung + OEM
API 29–37 emulators
Doze, reboot, clock shifts
Accessibility and battery

Release properly

Permanent signing key
apksigner verification
SHA-256 and changelog
Upgrade / restore rehearsal

Make the simple case impeccable first.

Each milestone ends in something testable, not an expanding pile of unverified features.

M0 PLATFORM PROOF	Native scaffold, verified image import, WallpaperManager and schedule spike
M1 USEFUL ALPHA	Rainbows import, collection, five-minute eligibility, shuffle and recovery
M2 DAILY DRIVER	Crop, share, widgets, tiles, backup, diagnostics and OEM fixes
M3 EXPRESSIVE ENGINE	Rules, nesting, scene simulator and legally approved content sources
M4 LIVE + POLISH	Optional effects, GPU and battery measurement, final UX refinement